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From the Editor in Chief's desk:
By Swami Paranand Tirth

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A concomitant transcendence as a means to salvation

Almost each metaphysical procedure in the Eastern mysticism has an uninterrupted lineage of preceptors. As the competence and diligence on the part of the disciples declined compendiums and books had to be compiled.

The viva voce tradition that predated the written revelation was not merely scholastic but aimed at the propagation of the ultimate experience. All aphoristic canons like Vatulanatha sutra etc. do not encrypt a postulation but formulae or knacks or upayas in order to induce the first hand experience. Anantanandnath, the

commentator on these Sutras tells us about the lineage. An adept named Gandmadan while redeeming his disciple Nishkriyanandnath confined to him a “book” that has never been written and thus enlightened him about the attainment of his supreme magnanimity.

By piercing through both covers of prana and Apana one enters the great void or Mahashunya. This mahashunya must not be confused with the shunyata of Buddhism, since the consequent sutra tells us about the seat in the self evident gnosis or samvit. Prana in this context is the current of bio energy that arises and circulates through the seven orifices and generates the experience of completion or purnavrtti. This prana is the upper sheath. Apana resides in the lower two apertures and accounts for the perception powers of the five senses of knowledge. Apana is metaphorically described as a serpent with five hoods which has five sheaths of five powers of the senses. This serpent has two coils of waking and dreaming state. As it undoes both of these knots the awareness transcends or pierces through both these covers or sheaths simultaneously and enters the great void. उद्घटनं as such is a type of repeated motion but Anant Shakti calls is विदारणं or rupturing both the prana and Apana .

Defining the attributes of the great void or mahashunyata the commentator says that it is beyond the states of identification with gross manifestation “kula” and disidentification with it that is “a kula”. Since the state of total transcendence is beyond all notions of word and meaning it cannot be taught like conventional knowledge, being limitless the mahashunya is not veiled and nothing can be conceptualized beyond it. There is no distinction of the known and the knower in it and this experience transcends all that can be described through alphabet and all that can’t be described through them. Besides it also is beyond all letters taken collectively. Since there is no distinction there is no contact, material or metaphysical and there is no absence of contact either. Since touching or not touching are possible only when there is difference. Only to distinguish it from all

conventional notions of Akasa or ether this has been termed as mahashunyata or the virtue of the great ether.

Entry or Pravesh is not like entering through some door into another realm. It is a total negation of all conditioning and attaining the ultimate unison. The term Samarasyam literally means homogeneity not because the two entities merge into one but a total absorption into the essential nature which is “one without a second” apriori. This is possible only after one has received the great dictum or has been ordained into this cult.

To emphasise this Anantanandnath has begun his exposition with an anecdote of an adept Gandhamadan as he redeems his novice named Niskriyanand Nath by imparting the wisdom of this particular knack or spiritual tactic .This concomitant transcendence of both conditioning has been said to lead to the ultimate objective of yoga ie Kaivalyam or absolute isolation.

Tantras provide the result through the munificence of a preceptor. What would take an eon by practising yoga “by preparing the bed of Yama and niyama (ethical foundation) , sowing the seed of asana and as the germination of pranayama and the vine of pratyahar as the leaves of dharana this yoga creeper bears the buds and flowers of dhyana and samadhi and finally the fruition of kaivalyam. A tedious process indeed!The concomitant transcendence leads to an incessant seat in the all conscious nature and thus kaivalyam without a knack or upaya says one canon on mysticism it is as tedious as emptying an ocean with the tip of blade of kusa grass.

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Editorial



Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher

Spiritual knowledge about the nature of true self can be transmitted in various ways. The written word in form of texts and expositions which nowadays have become the main source of knowledge probably being the grossest one. There are upayas or knacks which a preceptor shares with his competent disciple which can help the latter to see things differently. Possibly these disciples later composed the aphoristic texts for the people who probably were not that fortunate to receive it from the mouth of a guru.

Vijnanabhiarava Tantra is one such text which lays down 112 upayas while Pratyabhijna Hridayam, a digest composed by Kshemraj the ardent disciple of Abhinavaguptacharya talks about five potent upayas in its 18th sutra. This sutra literature was composed to help an aspirant climb the spiritual ladder but only reading it or mugging it up is of no use.

Explaining such transmission directly from the master to the aspirant in the Editorial our Guru maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirthji writes, "The viva voce tradition that predated the written revelation was not merely scholastic but aimed at the propagation of the ultimate experience. All aphoristic canons like Vatulanatha sutra etc. do not encrypt a postulation but formulae or knacks or upayas in order to induce the first hand experience." Thus Tantra provided a faster and more life affirming attitude to liberation.

Next we have Swamiji's enlightening article 'Wisdom from Shiva's Rattle drum' dealing with 'The Creation within the creator as a produce of his will'. In this article Swamiji talks about the two major drives through which desire expresses itself and accounts for the sustenance viz. the libido and the thanatic drive. Their metaphysical import has been explained by Swamiji through the fourth beat of Shiva's rattle drum (ai auch).

This is followed by Dr. Toshkani's erudite article on the 'Mekhal ritual of Kashmiri pandits'. Explaining the ceremony in detail the author with tremendous command on Kashmiri culture writes, "Mekhal" is what the Kashmiri Pandits call upanayana or yajnopavit (sacred thread investiture) and the whole range of ceremonies connected with it, though wearing the mekhala or the girdle of Munja grass is only one of them."

Next we have a write-up pondering about spiritual love by Geetika Kaw Kher titled, 'Hafiz: Mundane to divine love'. The moment Hafiz (famous Persian poet) realized that the beauty of 'Shakh-e-Nabat' (a lady whom he had seen in the elite part of the city and to whom he had lost his heart to) was merely a reflection of the beauty of the Almighty, he became restless and anxious to reach the all pervading Lord and to delve in mysteries of nature and hence started his journey inwards.

This is followed by an absorbing article by Ambika Talwar titled, 'Poetics of Longing into wholeness'. Talking about the spontaneity and inevitability of creation she writes, "The instant the inner and outer cohere, a whole thought is birthed—indeed, it is already present as seed invisible. Each moment we encounter awaits its manifestation in form. Whether it becomes a poem or is just an insight is not the point. The point is we are, in essence, continually creative

beings and we create continuously. We are poets even if we do not write poetry.”

In the end we have an interesting photo feature on Swamiji's recent yatra to Spiti valley with its breathtaking and mysterious religious importance broadly documented

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WISDOM FROM SHIVA'S RATTLED DRUM .

Ai auch - the fourth beat.

The Creation within the creator as a produce of his will:

Swami Paranand Tirth

Abstract-

The powers of knowledge and will of the creator are the principal agencies of creation. The two basic drives account for the sustenance. The absolute principle with his maya accounts for the universal manifestation. The concept akin to that is the one by Audulomi in Brahmsutras and the Shaiva doctrine of Kashmir .The aphorism is construed by Nandikeshwara to mean omkara or the primordial eternal word . The order of will wisdom and work –iccha jnana and kriya is explained. The fourteenth spoke of the mystic instrument shrichakram contains the encryption of the thirteen syllable Purti vidya or formula of completion.

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The lord is the supreme self and the creator of the universal phenomena at the same time there are some interjections in this coincidence. In order to be the universal self an entity must be beyond the trail of cause and effect or one must admit modifications in the ultimate principle who in this case must be any one or both of the fundamental and instrumental causes as the cause is imbibed in the effect. This sutra has the key to these queries says the commentator on the *karika* of Nandikeshwara.

This aphorism explains the power and process of the creation of the universal phenomena in two steps; first-the will to create and the second-the creation within the domain of the substratum, space and time continuum, as it were, are within the domain of the “created” phenomena. The will to create is in fact the will that interlaces the entire sentient creation in the form of “free will”. The innate

subconscious desire to reject bondage and compulsion in any form spontaneously interlaces and decrees almost all tendencies of all sentient creatures.

This desire expresses itself in the form of two major drives –the libido drive which has been interpreted by the oriental thinkers as the motivation for *paramanand prapti* i.e. the drive for attaining the supreme bliss. The other one being a thanatic drive which expresses itself in the form of the fear of death and deprivation, eastern thinkers have called this the drive for *sarvananrth nivritti* or eradication of all miseries. Individual “constricted will” may as a result of intellectual seasoning conduce to a similar understanding but this may or may not bend with the innate aspiration for “free will” which is per se. Even scientists have conserved some reactionary genetic patterns whenever the free will is restricted because of an aberrant cognitive environment.



<http://the-universe-inside-your-mind.blogspot.com/2013/01/qi-baishi.html>

Free will, as the esoteric rendering of the aphorism says –is the agency that accounts for the process of creation. The Supreme-being and his will both are supra-mundane where as the creation itself is corporeal. Ancient occidental thought did not admit that the creator pervades his creation. The recent inclusion of this concept in the Neo Semitic Theology and metaphysics is presumably an admixture of both concepts. Upanishads like many other corollaries of Vedic

thought invariably propound that the creator pervades his creation and some go as far as asserting that the creator himself becomes the creation. Space continuum must be a part of the creation or a posteriori of creation so the subtler spiritual space i.e. *chidakash* or the conscious ether turns out to be the substratum of even the subtlest of the creation and therefore the grosser forms of creation – we shall go into this detail in our essay ‘‘The order of universal manifestation’’ based on the next aphorism.



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In this interpretation one can perceive a slight bent towards the ancient school of *sphurattavada* of Audulomi Acharya and the later Kashmir shaive doctrine. The former propounds the universal phenomena as a projection of pre consciousness where as the latter depicts the concept of pre-existent 36 element ontology . The lord desired to project the universal phenomena pre-existent in a nascent form within himself. The effect, argues the commentator on Spanda Karika, cannot supersede the cause so the primeval cause also turns out to be all pervasive substratum and no amount of expansion, static or dynamic, can supersede it.

The twelfth vowel *ai* [*longa*] is derived from the eleventh vowel [*brevis*] by adding *a* to the

preceding one hence there is a unity of this syllable called Aikara and *ou* or the fourteen vowel *o* [*brevis*] becomes *longa au* by adding the *u* i.e. the third vowel to it. The essence of knowledge or *prajnanatma* unites with *Maya* i.e. becomes *aa u*. This has been deciphered according to the root *aa u avirbhava*. The root *au* refers to manifesting or springing forth, hence the juncture of three shaktis of will, wisdom and work lead to the manifestation of the universal phenomena which is contained within the creator since any other domain which would be an a posteriori of creation is yet to manifest.

*Ukaar jnana samogat sarvsambhutihishyate
[swarvimarshini]*

By uniting [will or ichha] with jnana the entire universe springs forth.

Pranaven jagadvyaptam mayam avatishthate.

The universe is pervaded by the syllable Pranava or the primordial eternal word of god and is situated within the domain of Maya or Shakti who is in turn of three types; jnana or knowledge the manifestation of *satoguna*, ichha or will as that of *rajoguna* and kriya as the manifestation of *tamoguna* or nescience.

These two syllables are the encryptions of the two powers of Parameshwara viz. Will and Wisdom, the third being Work or Action. This trio of Work, Wisdom and Will, as one tantric canon says, is in a different order in the empirical self or jiv shiva and reverse in shiva or the universal self.

*Jnana janya bhavet ichha ichha janya kriya
bhavet*

Jive tu viparatah

In the case of Shiva wisdom leads to will and will leads to work. *Aing* syllable is usually associated with the power of kriya or action in the same manner knowledge with *au* and the nasal with will, thus the whole aphorism means – the union of the three energies in the

manifestation of the universal phenomena. Brahman the absolute principle despite being universal self and beyond the trail of cause and effect desired to generate the universe within himself. Time and spatial manifestation is a posteriori of his desire to manifest as the grosser phenomena.

This process is explained by the Vedantist as pertaining to the secondary manifestation of the absolute principle which is conditioned in the triple attributions i.e. existence, consciousness and bliss. The author of Bhamati terms it as conditioning in *dwitaya sachiv*. This fourth aphorism justifies the absolute principle as also the primordial causation while conditioned in the secondary nature. The absolute lord is the universal self who contains the entire universe within himself. He is motivated by his power of will and due to sheer compassion he resolved to manifest the universe. Nandikeshwar in this verse has propounded the principle of monism and at the same time in order to attribute the order of creation to the universal self conceptualized his power of will which presumably decrees the *kriya* is in turn decreed by the power of *jnana* which is innate in him. The concept of the *jagat* being within also has the hints of the *sphuratta vada* or the theory that the phenomena that is implicit within the creator becomes manifest and is not superimposed or virtual. This however does not conflict the theory of *vivarta* since in one of its corollaries the creation of *ishwara* or *ishwar sristi* is not considered as virtual and superimposed only that of *jiva* is virtual this however is meant for an aspirant of mediocre competence. The interpreter of these aphorisms has used the term *vishpharitam sphar* as verb meaning expansion, may be used in the same sense as *unmeelanam*. The mode of creation however in parlance is *shabdi* or the word. Since the other conventional meaning of these aphorisms are supposed to have encrypted seed of the entire descriptive linguistic of Panini. The preceding of *Jnana Shakti* as we have already mentioned above has been derived by Nandikeshwara as the continuation of a and ee and the nasalis accent from the preceding

aphorism this generates the seed syllable of *jnanashakti* i.e. *aim*. The twelve vowels excluding four lingual with *ri* and *la* i.e. *ri* and *lri* are generated from this which also denotes elements from *shiva* up to *prakriti*, the inclusion of twelve vowels and twelve elements, from *Prakriti* to *Purusa*. The unison of *Prakriti* and *Purusa* will be further elaborated in the exposition of the mystic import of the sutra *kapaya* i.e. the twelfth one. The crux of the exposition of the meaning of this sutra has been given as the knowledge of *prakriti* and *Purusa*. These fourteen vowels have been latently intended to mean the fourteen *bhuvanas* and fourteen topographic configurations of the fourteen variations in this aphorism. This has been explained as follows in a context named *Mahamantra Prakashin* exposition of the great mantra in a book -Har Gauri Samvada.

O! Great empress, the essence is my universal self and you are verily the essence of my universal manifestation .

The mystic diagram with fourteen spokes* is your very encryption.

O! *Ambika* [little mother] our mantra called *turya* contains thirteen syllables **

When the time for creative diverge occurs this turns into *Bindu* and from this *Bindu* springs forth *Akshara* or the imperishable primordial syllable. All syllables originate as the *Bindu* explodes or becomes *sphota* – As a result of this *sphota* and origination of the syllables all elementary constituents of the phenomena originate in the order of ether, air, fire, etc.

*The fourth periphery of the mystic instrument called *Shri Chakram* has been indicated.

** This thirteen syllable mantra has been called *poortividya* in the tantras and denotes the unison of *Shiva and Shakti*.



Mekhal Ritual of Kashmiri Pandits

By Dr. S.S. Toshkhani

“Mekhal” is what the Kashmiri Pandits call upanayana or yajnopavit (sacred thread investiture) and the whole range of ceremonies connected with it, though wearing the mekhal or the girdle of Munja grass is only one of them. How they came to use the word for the whole samskara is not clear. But it seems that at some point in time it must have been for them the most important part of the sacred thread investiture ceremony as it stressed the vows of celibacy and purity of conduct as an essential prerequisite for the initiate to go to the Acharya to learn. Actually, upanayana, with which it has become synonymous, was in the beginning an educational samskara which was performed when the teacher accepted to take charge of the student and impart necessary education to him. According to Dr. Rajbali Pandey, it was made compulsory to make education universal. Slowly it began to lose its pure educational sense and assumed a ceremonious character with the investiture of the sacred thread, which took place at the end of the yajna performed to mark the initiation and became the main ritual. In course of time the boy initiated with the Gayatri mantra to enable him to read the Vedas, was regarded as having acquired the status of a dvija or ‘twice-born’.

Whatever the case may be, in Kashmir the samskara, whether called “mekhal” or yajnopavit, became a package of about twenty-four samskaras from vidyarambha or learning of alphabets to samavartana or the end of studentship. Interestingly, these include elements from even the prenatal samskaras like garbh-adana and siman-tonnayana. Even kahanethur (namakarana) and zarakasay (chudakarana or the first tonsure) if not performed at the prescribed time can be

combined with it. This has made mekhal or yajnopavit a prolonged affair lasting for hours together. However, it is the wearing of the sacred thread to which the greater significance or sanctity is attached. That may be so because it has come to be regarded by the Kashmiri Brahmins, as by Brahmins elsewhere in the country, an essential symbol of their Hindu identity.



Mekhal Maharaza in a Mekhal ceremony.

Let us have a look at some of the peculiarities of the samskara as performed by the Hindus of Kashmir. According to Laugakshi, the upanayana ceremony of a Brahman boy should be performed in the seventh year from birth or in the eighth year from conception, that of Kshatriya in the ninth year and that of a Vaishya in the eleventh year: “saptame varshe brahmanasyopanayanam navame rajanasya ekadashe vaishasya”. This differentiation between the ages of the initiates, however, has no relevance for the Kashmiri Hindus today as there was hardly any Kshatriya or Vaishya left among them after the advent of Islam in Kashmir. Optional ages have also been prescribed in the Grihyasutras in case of exigencies, the time limit for a Brahman boy being sixteen years. As the samskara has become purely ceremonial today, even this extended time limit is hardly adhered to and it is performed at a convenient time, generally a few days before marriage.

A uniquely Kashmiri and an essential preliminary ceremony performed a day or two prior to upanayana (and also marriage) is Divagon. The etymology of the word 'divagon' is not clear but it is probably derived from the Sanskrit 'devagamanai, meaning 'arrival of the gods'. The ceremony is performed for invoking the presence of gods, especially Ganesha and the Sapta Matrikas or seven mother goddesses, to bless the initiate or the boy or girl to be married. It begins with a ritual bath, called kani-shran, which is given to the initiate by five unmarried girls, pancha kanya, four holding a thin muslin cloth over his head at its four ends and the fifth pouring consecrated water with a pitcher. These days usually the officiating priest himself pours the water.

A havan is performed on the occasion amidst chanting of mantras by the presiding priest with the initiate offering oblations while facing the east. On the eastern wall, the motif of the kalpavriksha, supposed to be the abode of the goddesses in Nandanavana or the Garden of Paradise is painted with lime and vermilion. The kalpavriksha or the 'wish fulfilling tree' has a shatchakra (hexagon) made at its base symbolizing Shakti, and the drawing is called divta moon or the 'column of the gods'. At about the same time khir is prepared and poured into seven earthen plates called divta tabuchi or 'the plates of the gods'. Roth of rice flour and monga varya or fried cakes of ground moong are placed over the khir. The plates are consecrated with mantras and offered to the seven matrikas after which the khir with the moong cakes are distributed as naivedya. At the end of the ceremony, ladies take the seven earthen plates in a procession to river for visarjana. They go singing hymns and folksongs in the praise of the goddesses and praying for the long life and happiness for the initiate.

Another typically local feature that literally adds colour to the ceremony is krul - a vine scroll painted on the outer door of the house. This is usually done by the paternal aunt of the boy who executes the design of flower-laden creeper in different colours on a white background. As

the design is being executed with the sacred symbol Om at the top, ladies assemble outside and sing auspicious songs. A dish called veris distributed with rice flour rot is among all present.

Though painting the krul- krul kharun as it is called in Kashmiri- is sort of ritual art denoting auspiciousness, it has all the elements of folk art. In fact, it is one of the few Kashmiri folk arts still alive.

The divagon over, the yajna for Upanayana is performed much in the same manner as Hindus elsewhere perform it. A jyotistambha or jwala linga with a shatchakra base is drawn at the head of the agnikunda, with a rectangular configuration showing ayudhas like the mace, trident, bow and arrow etc. topped by a pataka. To the west of it seating arrangement is made for the officiating priests, the chief of whom is called 'tsandra taruk', literally meaning 'the moon among the stars'. The tsandra taruk sits on a special seat and leads the reciting of the mantras and also monitors the proceedings of the yajna. The child to be invested with the sacred thread is taken under the canopy where his father lights up the sacred fire. Then his hair is shaved off by the barber - in the ordinary way if he has already performed his zarakasay.

Then he is given a bath and made to wear a snana-patta (loincloth) kept in its place by a cotton cord called atya pan which is tied round his waist. He is also given an upper and lower garment dyed in saffron or yellow colour so that he is dressed up like a Brahmachari. The Grihyasutras though prescribe that the clothes of a Brahman initiate should be of kashaya or reddish colour. The ceremony of offering clothes to the Brahmachari is described in detail in the Laugakshi Grihyasutra along with the Vedic mantras to be recited on the occasion.

Kalasha Puja is performed before the actual ceremony of Upanayana starts. The kalasha, a pitcher filled with water, vishtara (shoots of kusha grass) and walnuts, is an important ritual object full of symbolic significance. It is

consecrated by making shrichakra and swastika marks on it with vermilion (sindoor) and placed on an ashtadala kamala (eight-petaled lotus) drawn with lime or rice flour on the ground at the ritual site towards the east and on the left side of the agnikunda. Kalasha Puja is a prolonged affair as the kalasha is said to contain the entire heavenly vault and is the seat of all the gods with Vishnu occupying its mouth, Rudra its neck, and Brahma its bottom. The group of matrikas is known to reside in the middle part. Indra, Kubera, Varuna and Yama all reside in it. Within the kalasha the planets and the gods are bonded together and above it there are seven naga deities guarding it. The kalasha is worshipped with flowers and rice grains (arghya) and the presence of all these deities is invoked with appropriate mantras so that the day is auspicious for the yajnopavit ceremony that is about to be performed. Kalasha Puja begins with the hymn ‘ Omkaro yasya moolam, portraying the Vedas as a wish-fulfilling tree (kalpavriksha) and praying to it for protection. In fact the Puja is performed at the beginning of all major rites of Kashmiri Hindus.

Mekhala-bandhana or maunji-bandhana is in itself a most important ritual related to upanayana performed in the process when a girdle of the Munja grass is tied round the waist of the Brahmachari (called “mekhali maharaza” in Kashmiri). Laugakshi and his commentator Vedapala elaborately describe this rite. Some symbolic acts take place before the guru (the officiating priest) takes charge of the initiate to be. The teacher makes the Brahmachari to go round the sacred fire and to place his foot on a stone, asking him to be firm and steadfast. Then he touches the heart of the pupil uttering the words: “Into my will take thy heart; my mind shall thy mind follow; in my word thou shalt rejoice with all thy heart; may Brihaspati join thee to me” (“mama vrata hridayam te dadami mama vachenekavratato jushasva Brihaspatih tva mayanuktak mahyam”). After this the Brahmachari takes curds thrice and approaches the teacher to be initiated. At this the teacher ties the girdle round the waist of the boy with

the words: “Here has come to me, keeping away evil words, purifying mankind as a purifier, clothing herself by power of inhalation and exhalation, with strength this sisterly goddess, the blessed girdle: “pranapanabhyam balamabhajanti sakha devi subhaga mekhaleyam”.

The mekhala or girdle in the case of a Brahman is to be made of Munja grass and at the end of upanayana is to be replaced by a cotton girdle, but as this grass does not grow in Kashmir, a girdle of Kusha grass or of cotton is tied. And strange though it may seem, the rite is increasingly being discarded even though the yajnopavit ceremony continues to be called mekhal.

The decks are now clear for the main and the most important rite - the investiture of the sacred thread. In Kashmir, wearing of the sacred thread was essential not only for initiating a young boy into Brahmanhood by teaching him to recite the Gayatri mantra but also an essential prerequisite that made him eligible for marriage. Yajnopavit, it must be noted, continues to be retained as one of the most important rituals because of this reason also. The astrologically chosen auspicious moment is, however, generally strictly adhered to. The boy takes a few steps to the north and it is his father who first puts the three cords of the sacred thread round his neck, which is then replaced by the set of three cords which the priest makes him wear with the mantra “yajnopavit am paramam pavitram”. In the meanwhile the boy is made to look at the sun. He is to put on another set of three-folds on being married -one for himself and one for his wife. While the father of the boy has a definite religious role to play, the mother and other close relatives gather around him with the ladies singing auspicious songs to make it a colorful occasion socially and everyone rejoicing and having a sense of participation.

There are some features, peculiarly regional in character, which are introduced at this stage. In one of them, to which we have referred earlier, the ladies of the family enact a performance

closely resembling simantonnayana. With the help of mulberry twigs (instead of Udumbara) husbands of these ladies put through the locks of their hair strands of narivan or protection cord in a manner that they dangle alongside the strings of their dejihors. It is believed that this helps newly married women to become mothers soon.

Another peculiar feature is the tekytal - the figure of the shrichakra over a rectangular configuration painted with vermilion or saffron paste on the top of the ladies' headgear. As an option the design may be cut out on coloured or golden paper and pasted on the headgear. Tekytaal shows how deeply Shaktism or the Mother Goddess cult has influenced the social and religious life of Kashmiri Pandits.

Yet another interesting and typically local feature in the Yajnopavit ceremony of the Pandits is varidan. Varidan is a kind of hearth specially made for the occasion by the potter, having thirty-six holes on which thirty-six sanivaris or small earthen vessels are placed for cooking rice for rituals purposes. The thirty-six holes correspond to the thirty-six categories mentioned in the Shaiva texts as the basic constituents of the manifested world. As the sanivaris are very small and are filled only ceremonially, rice is cooked separately also in a large pot to serve the ritual purpose.

Having worn the sacred thread, the Acharya gives him specific instructions about how to wear the sacrificial cord on different occasions. He then gives him a deerskin to wear, Laugakshi prescribes: "anah-anas-yam vasanam charishnu paridam vajyajinam dadh-eyamiti vachayannaineyam charma brahmanya prachh-ativaigyaghram rajanyam rauravam vaishya". That is, the skin of a black deer should be given to a Brahmana for wearing as an upper garment, the Kshatriya the skin of a tiger and the Vaishya that of a Ruru deer. Today the skin of a spotted deer is obtained for a Brahman boy for ceremonial wearing, the other two castes virtually not existing among Kashmiri Hindus. Dr. Rajbali Pandey quotes the Gopatha

Brahmana as saying that "the deerskin was symbolical of holy lustre and spiritual pre-eminence." It inspired a Vedic student to attain the spiritual and intellectual position of a Rishi". At the time of receiving the deerskin, the Brahmachari is made to look at the sun with the mantra tachchakshur devahitam".

The Acharya (priest) now hands over a staff to the Brahmachari so that he may set upon his journey as a traveler on the path of knowledge. Laugakshi prescribes that the staff should be of Palasha wood for a Brahman: "palasham dandam brahmanaya p-rayachchhati". As Palasha wood is not available in Kashmir, the Brahmachari is given a staff of the mulberry wood, which is readily available. But today what the priest hands over is a staff in name only; actually it is a twig which has no utility, except ceremonial, the modern student no longer going to the forest to study.

Having equipped the initiated with a girdle, deerskin and staff (which were considered necessary for the Vedic student going to study at his Acharya's place), the Acharya now imposes five commandments on him: "A Brahmachari art thou.

Take water. Do the service. Do not sleep in the daytime. Control your speech". Vedpala, the commentator of Laugakshi Sutras explains service (karma) as serving the Acharya, studying the Vedas etc.

Repeating five verses from the Vedas in which the Seven Rishis and the gods are requested to stimulate his (the brahmachari's) intelligence, he is made to repeat a sixth verse also which is a yaju about milking the sweet milk of the Vedas.

At this point the Brahmachari is to be shown the reflection of Agni or the burning sacrificial fire in a pot of ajya or clarified butter. This is called ajya darshan, which has been distorted to 'adi darshan' in Kashmiri. According to Laugakshi's prescription, it is to precede bhiksha or the round for alms. Sitting in front of the sacrificial fire with his face towards the east, the Acharya

is to teach the most sacred Savitri mantra in the Gayatri metre (and therefore known as the Gayatri mantra) to the Brahmana pupil, reciting it three times-”first pada by pada then hemistich by hemistich” and last of all the whole verse so that he is able to learn it properly.

Vedarambha, or the beginning of the study of the Vedas and vidyarambha, or learning of the alphabets, are both mixed up in the present way of performing the sacred thread ceremony. What happens is that after offering him the panchagavya or the five products of a cow (cow dung, cow’s urine, milk, curds and ghee), the teacher (impersonated by the officiating priest) makes the Brahmachari write some words on a thali in which finely powdered mud is scattered. The words generally written on this occasion are “Om svasti siddham” or “Om namah siddhaya” (Salutation to the Siddhas). The script in which this was originally written came to be known as the Siddham or Siddhamatrika script, an earlier form of Sharada. The teacher would make the child read what was written and explain its meaning to him. It may be noted that in Kashmir vidyarambha was regarded as a part of upanayana and not a separate samskara. The rite has, however, almost gone out of vogue now.

It is now that the Brahmachari gets up to ask for alms (bhiksha) for the Guru, which in effect means to collect money for the officiating priest. The first person he is supposed to approach according to the Kashmiri custom is his maternal aunt. Observing the necessary decorum has to address a lady he approaches for alms with bhavati bhiksham dehi, abid habi” (“Venerable lady, give me alms”) and a man with “bho bhiksham dehi, abid hasa” (“Venerable Sir, give me alms”). The etymology of the Kashmiri word ‘abid’ is, however, not clear. Some say it is the Kashmiri form of the Sanskrit word ‘abheda’, but though phonetically plausible, this does not sound convincing.

To conclude the yajna, the priest summons everyone for the last ahuti, offering a handful of

a mixture of soaked wheat grains and flowers. This is called athiphol, literally meaning a handful of grains and is to be offered as oblation. Everyone makes a beeline to receive the athiphol, making it sure that he or she is present during the samapti or the concluding moments of the day-long yajna. Hymns for the pacification of the gods and the planets are recited in a chorus led by the priests and there is a clamour for offering the athiphol into the fire as soon as the priest pronounces the last “svaha”. The priest then sprinkles water from the kalasha on everybody present and distributes the walnuts as naivedya. The water thus sprinkled is called ‘kalasha lav’ and the walnut as ‘kalasha doon’.

What is most interesting is that samavartana or the sacrament marking the end of the “student career” of the boy and his “return” home from the house of the Guru is treated as a part of the Yajnopavit ceremony. It is assumed that the boy invested with the sacred thread has completed his “studies” and has come back to the family. This is regarded as a very important period in the boy’s life as he is now supposed to be ready to share the responsibilities of the world and get married. In accordance with the spirit of Laugakshi’s ordain-ments, the boy Invested with the sacred thread is given new clothes and shoes to wear instead of the brahmachari’s garments. A muslin turban is tied round his head. He is made to stand on the vyug or a colourful mandala. Someone, usually a young friend of the initiate, or mekhali maharaza as he is called in Kashmiri, holds a parasol of flowers over his head. He is then taken in a procession to the riverbank for snana, the ceremonial bath as a snataka (one who has completed his studies). There, the priest, who also accompanies him, gives him instructions about washing the sacred thread and performing daily rites like the sandhya etc.. He is also taught how to offer libations of water to gods and ancestors. After this he returns home in a procession. In the meanwhile, ladies sing auspicious songs and perform a special dance in a circle, the origin of which could go back to

centuries. This is a unique feature of the celebrations.

The yajnopavita ceremonies do not end with the samavartana. On the next day a small homa known as 'koshal hom' (Skt. 'kushala homa') is performed to thank the gods that all has ended well.

Source: [Kashmir Sentinel](#)

(Dr. S.S Toshkhani is a poet, linguist, writer and a thinker. He has contributed substantially to Kashmiri heritage and carried out modern research in various fields of Kashmiri literature, history, religion, art and social sciences.)

Hafiz: Mundane to Divine Love

Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher

After keeping a vigil for 40 consecutive nights at the tomb of Baba Kuhi (an 11th C. AD Persian poet) the young man smitten by love was rewarded with a visit by angel (some suggest the angel was Khizr).

Angel: So you are bestowed with immortality and poetic excellence as promised by Baba Kuhi, now for your third boon, what is your heart's desire?

Stunned by the beauty of the angel the young man forgot the charms of his sweetheart whom he desired to possess and for winning whose heart he had kept the vigil. So enchanted was he by the grace and radiance of the former that He thought if Almighty's angel is so intoxicatingly beautiful how beautiful would be the Lord himself. And in a fit of ecstasy these words escaped his mouth Young man: I want God.....

The realization he was asking for was terribly difficult and required tremendous patience and true faith...he knew it.....it would have been so much simpler to have asked for his lady love...but then he would not have become Hafiz, one of the most renowned and loved poets of Iran. The moment he realized that the beauty of 'Shakh-e-Nabat' (a lady whom he had seen in the elite part of the city and to whom he had lost his heart to) was merely a reflection of the beauty of the Almighty, he became restless and anxious to reach the all pervading Lord and to delve in mysteries of nature. Nothing else could quench his thirst for eternal knowledge

How can your face show such beauty While here on Earth You are the image of inconsistency and faithlessness (From: "The Diwan of Hafiz Shirazi" Ed. By Michael R Brown, Translated by Parham Noori Esfandiani and Alan Dean)

These lines clearly point out his disillusionment with the material world. He began yearning for divine love . Many a time Hafiz's poems are

classified as love poems and their meaning taken literary. Though at the earlier stage he has written love poems solely dedicated to Shakh-e-Nabat but all his later poetry is dedicated to divine love.

Directed by the angel to go to Muhammad Attar and consider him as his Spiritual guru, Hafiz spent forty years of his life serving his master secretly. The story of his vigil made him known throughout Shiraz and the poetry he now wrote in praise of his Lord were sung in lanes and bylanes of the city. These poems were written essentially as love poems sung in the praise of the beloved with deep spiritual meaning in them. One can understand the contents very well in Indian context as we have had many saint poets like Meera bai, Andal etc. who considered themselves as lovers of Lord. But in Persia of that time his works came under lot of criticism. He was openly called a 'Kafir' and his works were constantly scrutinized by religious leaders.

All the opposition did not deter him at all. He also saw the wisdom and mercy of God manifesting through his Master Attar, and he composed many poems praising his Master and begging Attar to fulfill the promise of Union with God. When Hafiz went to visit Attar, Attar would ask Hafiz to read his latest poem, then he would spiritually analyze it for the sake of Hafiz and the other disciples, (this practice continued for forty years). Then the disciples would put tunes to the ghazals and the songs would soon be sung throughout Shiraz, with the fame of Hafiz continuing to grow. But by the end of forty years of serving Attar he became impatient to unravel the mysteries of unknown. That is when he decided to put himself to test again. This time he entered a circle that he had drawn on the ground. He had made up his mind to enter self-imposed 'Chehel Nashini', in which the lover of God sits within a circle for forty days and it was believed that if the devotee was successful in this difficult deed, the lord would grant him his heart's desire. Hafiz managed to perform this difficult task too but by the end of the penance he realized he had no desire left.

Thus he reached a stage of God realization where nothing mattered anymore and he wanted nothing. Feeling blissfully light and enlightened he came back to Attar and during the last eight years of his life he just wrote about the ultimate union. He no longer was the seeker of the beloved but he was the beloved himself.

In the poems written during this period one can often see traces of Advaita philosophy.

Only That Illumined One

Who keeps seducing the formless into form

Had the charm to win my heart

Only A perfect one

Who is always Laughing at the word 'two'

Can make you know of love

(From 'The Gift' Translated by David Landinsky)

The lines...laughing at the word 'two' clearly points out his faith in monism as well as critiques the system where God is looked upon as someone or something to be feared. Hafiz says he is in me, I am in him and this feeling underlines all his later poems. In his final years Hafiz gathered his disciples around him and began to teach them, using his poems to illustrate the various Spiritual points that he wanted them to understand. Because his fame had become so widespread and people were traveling from all parts of Persia and other countries to be in his presence, that he had to seclude himself to a degree to be able to continue to teach his chosen disciples, and to write his poems that were eagerly awaited by his many devotees, and his enemies who continued to plot against him.

At the age of sixty-nine due to a longtime sickness he left his earthly form to the chagrin of most of Shiraz. People from far and near came to pay their homage to the great poet. Hafiz's body was carried towards the Muslim burial ground in the rose-bower of Musalla, on

the banks of the Ruknabad, which he loved and praised in his poems, and to where he often walked and sat down to write many of his ghazals. "The Ulama of Shiraz, with his fellow clergy, refused to allow for Hafiz's body to be buried as a Muslim and claimed that his poetry was impious. The long knives that they had been trying to drive into his back were now fully on show, for he was no longer there to defend himself against them with his sharp wit and sense of irony.

"The followers of Hafiz and the many citizens of Shiraz began to argue with those who followed the orthodox point of view, and in the heat of the argument, someone suggested that they should ask the poet himself for the solution. The clergy, by now afraid of the size and fervor of Hafiz's supporters, reluctantly agreed to the suggestion of tearing up many of his poems into couplets and placing them into a large urn, and to call on a small boy in the crowd to select one couplet from it. The couplet that was selected was couplet no. 7 from ghazal 60: "'Don't you walk away from this graveside of Hafiz, because, although buried in mistakes, he is traveling to Paradise.'" "Even after death, Hafiz had, with tongue in cheek, outwitted his bitter rivals, and this practice of consulting his Divan as an oracle has continued from this incident To this day people ask the great philosopher poet:

Hafiz to ro be Shakh I Nabat Jawab e swalam
ra bede (Hafiz, You are sworn by Shakh I nabat
Give answers to my queries)



Poetics of Longing into Wholeness

~ Ambika Talwar

wild sage

wanders between rocks

singing flutes

Poetry appears like this sometimes. We walk into IT unaware that we would meet a poem. And IT would meet or find us. This IT (a poem) is simply a moment when something magically and instantaneously comes alive in us and transforms us.

Such a thing happens more often than we realize. It is as though we suddenly become aware of our innate capacities connecting with all that is vibrant and enlivening outside us. So our inner and outer worlds wink at each other as we move through life.

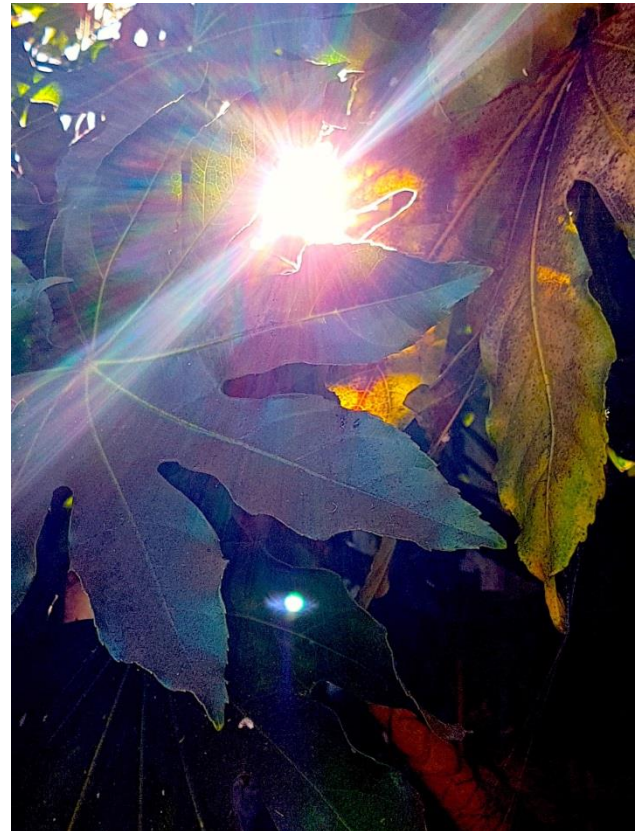
The instant the inner and outer cohere, a whole thought is birthed—indeed, it is already present as seed invisible. Each moment we encounter awaits its manifestation in form. Whether it becomes a poem or is just an insight is not the point. The point is we are, in essence, continually creative beings and we create continuously. We are poets even if we do not write poetry.

singular flute

singing beauty of stars

rainfall of light

We each are a “singular flute” awakening to our desire for exploration, an *autopoiesis* through which we recognize each singular expression and destiny as a unique voice. Also majestic are fragments of various singular destinies. Thus, in a world wrought by dire conflict and confusion, we recognize in this rain of light, that we collectively are carriers of virtue. But we must change our actions.



Title: How Sun Pierces Reality!

If what we are about to create has not yet become apparent to the conscious mind, it is already creating itself. When we actually become aware of this sudden winking, we are delighted, surprised, and enlivened. We feel we have an unusual privilege to explore and

express our deepest longing, so we may cherish life and be nourished by it.

Thusly, we are each a poem inspired by our own reflections. In turn, may we inspire each other.

sparkling leaf

our eyes prisms of joy

dancer's carpet...

Inspiring each other, we sparkle. We enter new worlds, which we create. Such prisms of joy surround us that every particle of us is entranced by beauty in our midst. Indeed, this weave of prismatic joy is a dance. We are continually in motion; our creating is a dance.

Imagine, if you will, moments of great insight, of excitement and wonder. Imagine being transported into other worlds where sparkling crystals mirror our delight. In such a state, let our witness self note how we move, halt, lift a hand or finger, pause, smile, weep. Note how our friend sings, runs, winks. Note how our child beseeches our indulgence. Note how we arrive at every step aware and enlivened. Perhaps, we are distracted by this delight and may be in a state of forgetting! But we know.

Our inner ear listens to rhythms in our patterns, how silence marks our step. Every act is a dance of delight, wonder, *eros*, courage, disgust, anger, victory, comedy, sorrow, laughter and tears. Such aesthetics weave the carpet we stand and walk on.

We are weaving a new carpet because it is time to do so. Shall it be woven with beauty and intelligence? Will shadows give it dimension so it continually awakens? Or will shadows pull us into obsessions that lead us away from truth?

May this weave be a foundation of virtues, so our poetry keep us ethical and in passionate longing.

rewoven gold

silk fabric endures

millennia of love

We recognize that love is an organizing principle of wholeness, a dance both emptying and filling. This *autopoietic* weaving is a unique coming to wholeness, a unitive process, and a perfecting design. It can be evolutionary for, in each moment, we have the power to choose the form and expression of our next thought and creation.

Let us remember that we are guardians responsible for the wellbeing and wholeness of all our relationships, with nature and with each other. An exploration of a new poetics is a natural result of our longing, awareness, and our essence, making poetry a “bridge to new worlds.”

The poetic is our conscience residing in expanding consciousness. As we create, we endow our selves and one another with responsibility, a choice-less participation with all that is. What we choose and how we act is a capacity to nourish, our “respons-ability.” Coupled with desire, we create a foundation upon which we may now carve our individual and collective destiny: to become that Love we long for.

Cells love it

when we smile

even if worlds break

*Nothing matters
but the Great Empty
from which all comes...*

*Chalice is passages
for flow of fountain*

*Always traveler longs
for this Void, this nourishment
flowers grow here...*

Are flowers not grace? Are we not channels for
wonder of divinity? Is not our body-being an
ever-renewing poem?

It is this ever-renewing connection with divinity
that urges our unfolding into sacred awareness.
With each experience of recognizing our body-
being as a chalice, we aware and arise in
radiance and develop resonant frequencies for
our life path despite the sometime thorny roads
we traverse.

We unfold as we continue the process of self-
creation; living is a deeply profound practice of
seeding joy and equanimity recognizing our
natural interconnectedness.

The time now is ripe for another re-creation of
gathering our strengths, our playful wisdom, our
longing, and our creativity to re-form into a new
model of sentience, kosmic and local, beyond
sustainability. Let us shed the ache of longing
and face our-selves in each other's hearts. Let
us gaze. What we long for is not so far away
any more.

*The more me I become,
the more I see you.
I do not know yet what that means,
or looks like—
Perhaps as sky and gaia inter-are,
so are we.*

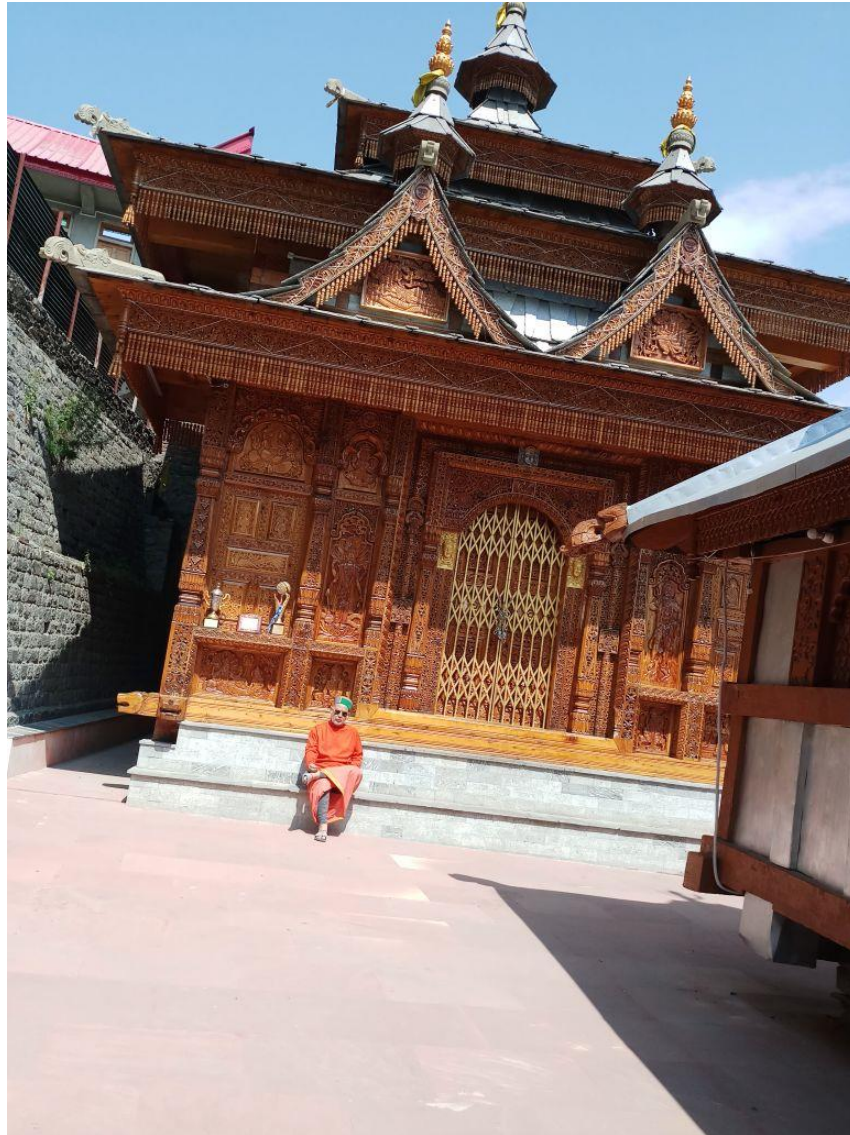
*I'd love for you to show it to me.
For in knowing me,
you know yourself.
as trees do
and parrots that sing in them.*

*Eagles tear away piece of blue
scope vast rolling green
where we walk.
Summer wind
lifts skin of puddles
and we laugh.*

(Note: This current version of the essay is quite a bit re-
edited and re-titled for this edition. An early version was
previously titled "Celebrating Our Creative Spirit" and was
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version appears in the book titled, *Poetry as a Spiritual
Practice: Embracing the Awakened Woman!* edited by
Catherine Ghosh)

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artist and is currently teaching English in Cypress
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Photo Feature on 'Divine Marvels of Spiti Valley'



SWAMIJI AT A VILLAGE AT KALAPI (KALPA GRAM).

Two yogins Maru, the son of Ishvaku and Devapi, the brother of Shantanu reside here in a subtle form. They will revive Dharma in the eon of Kali when it gets on the verge of extinction.



SWAMIJI AT BIMA KALI, THE FEROCIOUS FORM OF GODDESS KALI

Bhima, the mightiest of all Pandavas is said to have felicitated her for victory in the battle of Mahabharata. Hence the name Bhima Kali



SWAMIJI AT AN 8TH CENTURY TANGYUD MONASTERY



**MYSTERIOUS
MUMMY AT KAZA**



DRIVING AT 15,000 FEET FROM SEA LEVEL



SWAMIJI AT TABO WITH A LAMAGURU



TAKING A STROLL AT CHANDRA TAL



MEDITATING AT CHANDRA TAL



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